



George VI at his coronation in Westminster Abbey on May 12. He ascended the throne following the abdication of his brother, Edward VIII.

“ I SEE ONE-THIRD OF A NATION ILL-HOUSED, ILL-CLAD, ILL-NOURISHED. ”

Franklin D. Roosevelt, American president, in his inauguration speech, January 20, 1937

THE YEAR BEGAN WITH FRANKLIN D. ROOSEVELT starting his second term in office as US president. In his inauguration speech on January 20, Roosevelt drew attention to **persistent poverty** in America. He pledged to end this injustice, denouncing “heedless self-interest” as bad morals and bad economics. The president’s **radical policies** brought him into conflict with the Supreme Court, while across the country a wave of **sit-down strikes** pitted workers against their employers. As the number of jobless more than doubled between 1936 and 1938, it was not obvious that Roosevelt’s approach was working. This period was ironically dubbed “Roosevelt’s Depression.”

For Britain and its empire, this was a year of change. In May, the country saw a **new king crowned**, George VI (1895–1952), and a new

prime minister in Downing Street, Neville Chamberlain (1869–1940). In Ireland, a referendum in July approved a proposal for a new constitution. The **Irish Free State became Eire** (Ireland in Gaelic), and in effect a fully independent country, although officially still a dominion of the British Commonwealth. British India took another step toward self-government with implementation of the **India Act**, but the limited powers of its elected assembly fell far short of satisfying Indian nationalists. The British also failed to find a solution to the

Picasso’s vision of war
In response to the German bombing of the Basque town of Guernica, Pablo Picasso painted this large mural in support of the Spanish Republicans. It was displayed at the 1937 Paris Exhibition.

problem in **Palestine**, and their proposal to split it between the Jews and Arabs was rejected by both sides.

In Spain, the ongoing civil war (see 1936) was progressing badly for the Republican Loyalists. Political divisions, with Communists determined to suppress anarchists and Trotskyists, nullified the courage and determination of their military efforts. The Nationalist rebels continued to enjoy the support of German and Italian forces, especially in the air. On April 26, the Basque town of **Guernica** became famous worldwide when, on a busy market day, it was

devastated by aircraft of the German Condor Legion. Estimates of the death toll varied from 300 to 1,700. Graphically described by journalists who visited the town in the wake of the attack, the event focused **fears about aerial bombardment**, specifically the impact of the German Luftwaffe in any future war between the major powers.

In an increasingly divided world, art and literature were becoming politicized. **Prominent writers went to Spain**, either to fight in the Civil War (mostly on the Republican side) or as war tourists and journalists. Among these were George Orwell and

W. H. Auden from Britain, Ernest Hemingway from the US, and André Malraux from France. The most famous response to the bombing of Guernica was Pablo Picasso’s painting, which was first exhibited in the Spanish Republic’s pavilion at the Paris International Exhibition in summer 1937.

The **Paris Exhibition** also featured grandiose Nazi German and Soviet Russian pavilions, both using monumental sculpture to trumpet the glories of their rival political systems. The Nazis also took the extraordinary decision to mount a show of the art they despised, displaying confiscated



“ AT 2 A.M. TODAY WHEN I VISITED THE TOWN, THE WHOLE OF IT WAS A HORRIBLE SIGHT, FLAMING FROM END TO END. ”

George Steer, British journalist, reporting the bombing of Guernica for *The Times*, April 27, 1937

